

Grants & Support for People with Disabilities

Entrepreneurs with disabilities have dedicated funding, free expert help, and programs that let you start a business without losing your benefits. Below are trusted national resources. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Important: there are ways to start a business while protecting your SSI/SSDI benefits (ask about a PASS plan). Much of the help below is free. Beware of anyone charging fees for "disability grants."

1 Free Expert Help

Specialists who understand both business and disability.

☐ National Disability Institute — Small Business Hub

Free business planning, financial coaching, and grant access for entrepreneurs with disabilities.

→ www.nationaldisabilityinstitute.org/achieve-small-business-success

☐ Job Accommodation Network (JAN)

Free guidance on self-employment, financing, and accommodations.

→ askjan.org/topics/entrepreneurship.cfm

2 State Vocational Rehabilitation

VR agencies can fund and support self-employment goals.

☐ Vocational Rehabilitation Self-Employment

Your state VR agency may help fund equipment, training, and startup costs for a business.

→ rsa.ed.gov/about/states

3 Protect Your Benefits

Start a business without automatically losing SSI/SSDI.

☐ SSA PASS Plan (Plan to Achieve Self-Support)

Lets you set aside income/resources toward a work goal — like starting a business — without losing SSI.

→ www.ssa.gov/disabilityresearch/wi/pass.htm

☐ ABLE Accounts

Tax-advantaged savings that don't count against most benefit limits — useful for business savings.

→ www.ablenrc.org

4 Funding & Grants

Loans and grants that support disabled entrepreneurs.

☐ Disability Opportunity Fund (CDFI)

Loans and technical help for businesses owned by people with disabilities.

→ thedof.org

☐ NASE Growth Grants

Up to \$4,000 grants for self-employed members (open to disabled entrepreneurs).

→ www.nase.org/become-a-member/grants-and-scholarships/business-development-grants

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Be cautious of “disability grant” sites charging fees. And before earning business income, check how it affects your benefits — a free benefits counselor (ask NDI or your VR office) can set you up safely with a PASS plan.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Talk to a benefits counselor before you start earning — with the right plan (like PASS), you can build a business and keep your support during the transition instead of losing it overnight.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national resources. For your state VR office and local disability-business programs, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
